

Preparing for Ludovico Einaudi's “Experience” using Hanon Exercises

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This report provides a comprehensive analysis of the technical demands found in Ludovico Einaudi's piece “Experience” and pairs those specific demands with targeted exercises from *The Virtuoso Pianist* by C.L. Hanon. The goal is to provide a structured practice regimen that builds the exact technical skills required to perform the piece fluently and expressively.

1. Methodology

The recommendations in this report were developed through a systematic analysis of both the sheet music and the exercise book.

First, the sheet music for “Experience” was examined to identify its key signature, time signature, tempo markings, and primary technical challenges. The analysis focused heavily on the right-hand (RH) 16th-note patterns, the left-hand (LH) sustained chords, hand independence, and the stamina required to perform the piece.

Next, the Hanon exercise book was cataloged by reviewing the structure of Parts I, II, and III. The specific mechanical focus of each exercise (e.g., finger independence, thumb crossings, scale preparation) was noted.

Finally, the technical demands of the piece were cross-referenced against the cataloged Hanon exercises to select the most relevant and beneficial practice routines, including the specific major scale exercise that corresponds to the key of “Experience.”

2. Analysis of “Experience”

Musical Framework

The piece is composed entirely in **E major**, indicated by the key signature of four sharps (F#, C#, G#, D#). It opens in $\frac{4}{4}$ time and maintains this meter until a brief shift to $\frac{2}{4}$ near the end during the *più lento* section. The tempo markings demand flexibility, starting *Freely* at $\text{♩} = 72$, establishing the primary pulse at a *tempo* $\text{♩} = 92$, and concluding with a broad *allargando*.

Primary Technical Demands

Continuous Right-Hand 16th-Note Patterns The defining characteristic of the piece is the near-unbroken stream of 16th notes in the right hand spanning approximately 95 bars. These patterns consist of arpeggiated, broken-chord figures that cycle through the harmonies. Executing this requires exceptional finger evenness, so that no single finger dominates the texture, and significant physical endurance to maintain a relaxed wrist over a long duration.

Hand Independence and Left-Hand Voicing While the right hand plays rapid, continuous patterns, the left hand primarily sustains whole-note chords, often spanning wide intervals such as octaves or tenths. The performer must maintain these sustained voicings without tension while the right hand moves freely. In the climax sections, both hands become rhythmically active, requiring advanced bilateral coordination.

Thumb Crossings and Finger Substitution The right-hand arpeggiated figures frequently require smooth thumb-under and finger-over movements. Because the piece is in E major, these crossings often navigate the black keys (F#, C#, G#, D#), which requires precise thumb positioning to avoid unevenness or stumbling.

Dynamic Control Within Repetition The repetitive nature of the right-hand pattern requires the performer to execute the exact same physical motions across a wide dynamic range, building from *mezzo-piano* to *fortissimo* and dropping suddenly to *piano*. This demands fine touch control and the ability to modulate arm weight without altering the fundamental hand shape.

3. Recommended Hanon Exercises

Based on the technical demands identified in “Experience,” the following exercises from the Hanon book have been selected to build the necessary foundational skills.

Foundational Evenness and Independence (Part I)

To address the continuous right-hand 16th-note patterns and ensure equal tone across all fingers, the following Part I exercises are highly recommended:

Exercise	Focus Area	Relevance to “Experience”
Exercise 1	Basic five-finger evenness	Establishes the foundational evenness required for the repetitive 16th-note streams.
Exercise 5	Independence of the 3rd, 4th, and 5th fingers	Strengthens the naturally weaker fingers, which are heavily utilized in the upper notes of the right-hand broken chords.
Exercise 8	Extended independence of the 3rd, 4th, and 5th fingers	Builds endurance in the outer fingers, crucial for the long duration of the piece.

Advanced Coordination and Thumb Crossings (Part II)

To prepare for the hand independence and the specific thumb movements required by the arpeggiated patterns, the following Part II exercises should be incorporated:

Exercise	Focus Area	Relevance to “Experience”
Exercise 21	3-4-5 finger focus in contrary motion	Builds bilateral hand independence, helping the left hand remain stable while the right hand moves.
Exercise 34	Turning the thumb under the 4th finger	Directly prepares the hand for the smooth thumb crossings required in the E major arpeggiated patterns.
Exercise 35	Turning the thumb under the 5th finger	Essential for the wider broken-chord figures where the thumb must pivot smoothly under the outer hand.

4. The Applicable Scale Exercise

Because “Experience” is written entirely in **E major**, mastering the E major scale is the single most important technical preparation for the piece. The Hanon book provides a comprehensive section on scales in Part III.

Preparatory Scale Work

Before attempting the full scale, the student should practice **Exercise 38** (located on page 55 of the PDF). This exercise is specifically designed as a “Preparatory exercise for the study of scales” and isolates the thumb-under motion required for scale fluency.

The E Major Scale Exercise

The specific scale exercise for the key of “Experience” is found in **Exercise 39, located on page 65** of the Hanon PDF.

This section provides:

1. The **E major scale** over four octaves, utilizing the standard fingering (Right Hand ascending: 1-2-3-1-2-3-4-1).
2. The relative minor scales (**C# minor**), presented in both harmonic and melodic forms.

Practicing the E major scale from Exercise 39 will directly train the fingers to navigate the four sharps (F#, C#, G#, D#) that form the harmonic vocabulary of the entire piece. It is recommended to practice this scale with a metronome, gradually increasing the tempo from ♩ = 60 to ♩ = 120, to match and eventually exceed the ♩ = 92 tempo marking found in the Einaudi score.

5. Practice Strategy Summary

To effectively prepare for “Experience,” structure your daily technical practice as follows:

1. **Warm-up (10 minutes):** Begin with Exercises 1, 5, and 8 to establish finger evenness and awaken the 3rd, 4th, and 5th fingers.

2. **Coordination (5 minutes):** Practice Exercise 21 to build the hand independence required for the contrasting left and right-hand roles.
3. **Thumb Technique (10 minutes):** Work through Exercises 34, 35, and 38 to ensure smooth thumb crossings, focusing heavily on keeping the wrist relaxed.
4. **Scale Mastery (10 minutes):** Conclude the technical session with the E major scale from Exercise 39 (Page 65). Focus on even tone and fluid thumb transitions across the black keys.

By isolating these specific mechanical challenges using the Hanon exercises, the technical execution of “Experience” will become automatic, allowing the performer to focus entirely on the expressive and dynamic qualities of the music.